Event Design Document: 24-Hour Devlympics

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1. Core Event Idea

The Concept

A 24-hour building competition where teams do not solve predefined problem statements. Instead, they build creative projects inspired by a broad, open-ended **Theme** that is chosen by participants through a live vote and revealed only at the start of the event.

Unlike traditional hackathons, each theme represents a fundamental idea or challenge rather than a specific domain. This gives teams complete freedom to interpret it through web applications, mobile apps, games, AI, hardware, data visualisation, or any other form of technology.

Why Game Jam Style?

- **No Pre-built Projects** — The theme is voted on and revealed live, ensuring a fair start for everyone.
- **Complete Creative Freedom** — Teams can build web apps, mobile apps, or games — as long as it fits the theme.
- **Focus on Building, Not Pitching** — The goal is to make something functional and fun, not a business slide deck.

2. Key Elements of the Event

The Live Theme Vote & Reveal

Before coding begins, participants choose the challenge that will define the entire hackathon. Each theme follows a common structure:

- Title
- Theme
- Description
- Rookie Starting Points
- Creative Edge

- Central Question

During kickoff:

- Organizers present each theme.
- Participants have approximately **15 minutes** to review them.
- Every participant casts one vote.
- The winning theme is immediately revealed.
- Teams then begin brainstorming and building.

The themes are:

- Forbidden Knowledge
- Risk It for the Biscuit
- Pass It On
- Bridge the Gap

Because themes are intentionally broad rather than problem-specific, teams are free to interpret them in entirely different ways. Two projects built under the same theme should be able to look completely different.

The Chaos Engine (Unexpected Twists)

Every few hours, organizers announce fun, temporary constraints that teams must incorporate. They are explained further in the document.

Digital-First, No Paper

All submission-based mechanics (chits, time capsules, bug entries, final notes) run through **online forms** rather than physical paper. This keeps everything trackable, timestamped, easy for mentors/organizers to manage, and genuinely anonymous where needed.

3. The Themes / Problem Statements

1) Forgotten Knowledge

Theme

Create something that helps people remember, rediscover, or reconnect with knowledge that would otherwise be forgotten.

Description

Learning is not only about acquiring new knowledge but also about retaining it over time.

People naturally forget information, skills fade without practice, and valuable ideas are often lost because they are not revisited at the right moment. Sometimes forgotten knowledge becomes useful only months or years later.

The knowledge could involve:

- concepts learned long ago but no longer remembered;
- practical skills that weaken without use;
- personal notes or insights that become relevant again;
- connections between topics that were never recognised;
- experiences that can teach future lessons;
- community or cultural knowledge that risks disappearing;
- information buried in books, documents or digital archives;
- learning that needs reinforcement rather than repetition.

Your project should help users preserve, rediscover, strengthen or meaningfully revisit knowledge. It does not need to stop forgetting entirely—forgetting is a natural part of learning. Instead, it should make forgotten knowledge easier to recover or more valuable when it returns.

Rookie starting points

A beginner team could build:

- **Smart Revision Planner** — A tool that schedules reviews based on how likely a learner is to forget a topic.
- **Memory Vault** — An app that resurfaces old notes, bookmarks or journal entries when they become relevant.
- **Skill Refresher** — A platform that generates quick practice sessions for skills that have not been used recently.
- **Knowledge Timeline** — An interactive timeline showing what a user has learned and

suggesting when to revisit previous topics.

Creative edge

Experienced teams could explore:

- personalised forgetting models;
- AI that predicts when knowledge will become relevant again;
- knowledge graphs linking old and new concepts;
- long-term memory systems for AI assistants;
- context-aware reminders based on location, activity or current work;
- multimodal memory aids using voice, images, wearables or AR;
- collaborative knowledge preservation across communities or generations.

Central question

How can we make knowledge available not just when it is learned, but when it is needed most?

2) Risk It for the Biscuit

Theme

Create something that helps people decide when a possible reward is worth the risk.

Description

People constantly choose between taking a safe option and risking something for a potentially better result.

The risk could involve:

- spending more time for a better outcome;
- trying an unfamiliar opportunity;
- trusting another person;
- sharing information;
- taking a different route;
- investing limited resources;
- experimenting instead of following the usual method;
- continuing when the current result is already acceptable.

Your project should help users understand a risk, experience its consequences, or make a more informed choice. It does not need to eliminate risk the uncertainty may be the most important part.

Obvious directions to look for

Start by looking at decisions people already make in everyday life. Find a situation where someone must choose between a safe, predictable option and an uncertain option with a potentially better reward. Think about what is being risked, what could be gained, what information the person has, and how your project could help them understand or experience that choice.

Some examples include:

- Opportunity Board — A platform that compares the possible benefits, effort and uncertainty of competitions, internships or events.
- Battery Bet — A mobile tool estimating whether the remaining battery will survive a planned journey or activity.
- Study Strategy Simulator — A tool comparing safe revision with spending time learning a difficult but rewarding topic.
- Push Your Luck Game — A game where players choose whether to secure their progress or risk it for a higher score.

Creative edge

These are only starting points, not limits on what can be built. Teams are free to interpret risk and reward in any context, medium or form. The strongest projects may take the theme in an unexpected direction while still making the central choice between safety and possibility meaningful.

Central question

What would make someone reasonably choose the risky option?

3) Bridge the Gap

Theme

Create something that connects two sides separated by differences in knowledge, access, language, ability or technology, allowing them to understand or interact with one another more effectively.

Description

Many people, systems and environments could work better together but are separated by a gap.

The gap might exist between:

- beginners and experts;
- students and opportunities;
- humans and machines;
- digital and physical environments;
- different languages;
- people with different abilities;
- creators and audiences;
- old and new technology;
- complex information and ordinary users;
- people who have resources and people who need them.

The “gap” does not have to be a serious social problem. It could also be technical, physical, informational, generational or even fictional.

Build something that acts as the bridge between these two sides. Your project might translate information, simplify an interaction, improve access, create a shared experience or introduce an entirely new way for the two sides to connect.

Obvious directions to look for

Start by identifying two sides that should be able to communicate, understand one another or work together, but currently cannot do so easily. Think about what separates them, what each side needs from the other and what your project could place between them to make that exchange possible.

Some examples include:

- **Opportunity Translator** — Turn complicated internship, competition or scholarship requirements into clear, personalised steps.
- **Accessible Interface** — Redesign a complex digital service for elderly users, children or people with different abilities.
- **Loading Screen Reimagined** — Turn waiting time into a bridge between the user and what the system is doing through explanations, previews or small interactions.
- **Physical-to-Digital Connector** — Use sensors, gestures or physical objects to control or communicate with a digital environment.

Creative edge

These are only starting points, not limits on what can be built. Teams are free to interpret the “gap” in any context, medium or form. The strongest projects may connect two sides that do not appear related at first, or redefine what it means to act as the bridge between them.

Central question

Which two sides should be able to connect, and what could exist between them to make that possible?

4) Pass It On

Theme

Create something that changes, improves or gains value as it passes through multiple people, systems or stages.

Description

Information, knowledge, objects, responsibilities and experiences constantly move from one person or system to another. Usually, something is lost, misunderstood or weakened during this transfer.

What if the opposite happened?

The thing being passed could be:

- a story changed by every person who tells it;
- an idea improved through different perspectives;
- an object modified by each person who receives it;
- information refined as it moves through different systems;
- a responsibility handed between people with different abilities;
- a digital artefact that evolves with every interaction;
- a message whose meaning changes depending on its path;
- a challenge where each participant builds upon the previous attempt;
- a resource that becomes more useful as more people contribute;
- an experience shaped collectively over time.

Build something where passing is not merely transportation. Each participant, system or stage should leave a meaningful contribution, causing the final result to differ from where it began.

Core requirement

At least three distinct participants, systems, agents or stages must contribute to the final outcome.

Stage 1 → Transformation → Stage 2 → Transformation → Stage 3

The final result must meaningfully differ from the initial input.

Obvious directions to look for

Start by choosing something that can be passed from one participant or stage to another. Decide what each participant can add, remove, reinterpret or transform, and how those contributions accumulate over time. Think about why the final result becomes more useful, interesting or valuable because of the journey it has taken.

Some examples include:

- **Evolving Story** — Each participant continues a story without seeing everything written before them.
- **Idea Relay** — One person proposes an idea, another identifies problems and a third improves it into a possible solution.
- **Collaborative Artwork** — Every participant adds a new visual element based on what the previous person created.
- **Knowledge Chain** — A difficult concept is passed through several users, with each person simplifying or illustrating it further.
- **Digital Object With History** — A virtual object changes appearance, abilities or meaning whenever someone receives it.
- **Build-on-the-Previous Game** — Each player modifies the rules, level or challenge before passing it to the next player.

Creative edge

These are only starting points, not limits on what can be built. Teams may interpret “passing” physically, digitally, socially, technically, competitively, collaboratively or fictionally. The strongest projects may explore unexpected transformations or make the journey itself more meaningful than the final result.

Central question

What could become better if multiple people or systems contributed to it over time?

4. Event Timeline (The 24 Hours)

Phase 1: The Vote, Reveal & Brainstorming

- **Hour 0.00 — Live Ballot:** Voting opens for the theme.
- **Hour 0.15 — The Reveal:** Winning theme is revealed.

Phase 2: The Core Build

- **Coding Begins:** Teams start building core features.
- **Twists:** Rolled out at intervals via the Chaos Engine.

5. Judging Criteria

Criteria	**What It Means**
Theme Interpretation	How creatively and clearly the team used the main theme.
Fun / Experience	Is the project enjoyable, interesting, funny, or memorable?
Creativity & Originality	Is the idea fresh, weird, clever, or unexpected?
Execution	Not "perfect code" — just a functional demo. Do they have a working demo, or are they faking it with UI only?
Presentation	Was the final pitch fun? How well did it convey the idea? How unique was the delivery?
Fun Twists	Did the team participate in twists — meme integration, best bug clips, etc.?

6. Fun Twists (Finalized Set)

Teammate Swap

- One member from a team gets swapped with another team for around 45 minutes.
- **Goal:** force collaboration, fresh ideas, and chaos.

Project Time Capsule

- At the start, each team submits (via form) a 1–2 line description of what they think they will build.
- At the end, mentors compare that original idea with what the team actually built.
- This becomes funny because some teams will match their idea, some will evolve it, and some will end up somewhere completely unexpected.

Presentation Style Challenge

- Around 4–5 hours before the final pitches, teams are given a pool of presentation styles to choose from — e.g., TED Talk, News Anchor, Movie Trailer, Pirate, Alien, Sports Commentator, Nature Documentary Narrator (National Geographic), etc.
- Teams may propose another style with prior approval from the organizing team.
- The chosen style must not interfere with the technicality and specificity of the pitch — it should merely enhance it, making it more engaging and fun.
- **Goal:** encourage creativity and adaptability while keeping the project pitch clear.

Meme Integration Challenge

At some point during the hackathon, mentors announce one meme / funny phrase that every team must somehow include in their project.

Examples:

- "It works on my machine"
- "Trust me bro"
- "Task failed successfully"
- "Skill issue"
- "404 motivation not found"
- "Bro just ship it"
- "This was intentional"

Teams can include it anywhere: error message, loading screen, button text, chatbot response, hidden easter egg, fake review, or final demo line.

This twist is low-effort to run — mentors only need to announce the meme, and teams show it during their demo.

Funny Feature Chit Challenge

Within each mentor group, teams submit funny feature ideas via form.

Example chit ideas:

- Add a panic button.
- Add a fake premium feature.
- Add a useless button.
- Add a dramatic warning.
- Add a tiny mascot.
- Add a secret villain.
- Add a random insult generator.
- Add a "boss mode."
- Add a button that does nothing but looks important.
- Add a feature that makes the project unnecessarily emotional.

Then either:

- teams randomly pick one chit, **or**
- the mentor randomly assigns one chit to each team.

Each team must implement that feature somehow, even if it is tiny.

Veto rule: If a submitted or assigned chit is too extreme or unreasonable ("crazy crazy") for the time and scope available, mentors can return the chit to the team so they now have to add that feature.

This twist works well because it creates interaction between teams without needing constant mentor supervision.

Bug Hall of Fame / Best Bug Award

During the event, every team can submit a photo or video of their funniest bug via form.

Examples: broken UI, cursed error, weird animation, backend crash, unexpected output, funny AI response, "it was working 5 minutes ago" moment.

At the end, judges rate the submissions and give a Best Bug Award.

Possible award names:

- Best Bug Award
- Most Cursed Bug
- Bug Hall of Fame
- It Worked 5 Minutes Ago Award
- Task Failed Successfully Award
- Best Unintentional Feature

This is especially good because even failures become part of the fun.

Anonymous Final Chit

At the end of the event, every participant can anonymously submit a form response.

They can write anything: funny confession, roast, appreciation, "what went wrong," "what saved us," funniest team moment, message to mentors, message to judges, random hackathon quote, emotional note, inside joke.

No name field — fully anonymous.

Organizers/mentors read selected submissions out loud at the end.

This is great for closing the event because it gives everyone a voice, even quieter participants.